

us, the more the merrier."

Former Maharashtra governor S.M. Krishna had come back to Karnataka hoping to be the urbane face of the party and also mop up the 12 per cent Vokkaliga votes for the Congress. He enthused into action his trusted lieutenant, wealthy educationist and fellow Vokkaliga D.K. Shivakumar but neither appear on the list of candidates. In Krishna's home district Mandya also, the hotbed of the Cauvery water agitation, there is widespread frustration with the Congress over allotment of tickets. Most of the leaders who haven't got tickets have already opened lines of communication with BJP, which, in turn, is keen to draw on their popularity. Kumaraswamy, on the other hand, has restarted his community interaction scheme "Gram Vastavya" or village home stay programme on a high and father Deve Gowda is actively wooing minority communities, especially the Muslims. He broke new ground some months ago by appointing a Muslim, Merajuddin Patel, as the JD(s) state unit president.

The Congress also has to reckon with veteran leader C.K. Jaffer Sharief, for long its Muslim face in the state. He is upset over his grandson Abdul Wahab Sharief being denied a ticket. Abdul's father Khader Nawaz Sharief was being groomed to take forward Sharief's legacy a few years ago but he died sometime back. Sharief contends that the 12 per cent Muslim vote is crucial for the Congress which has to compete with JD(s) and BSP. Their votes can make a big difference to the party in nearly a hundred Assembly segments in the state. "They have traditionally voted for the Congress and the community can be key to the party's victory," says Congress leader Roshan Baig, who has been given a ticket. It was the Congress's strategy to encourage young leaders like Rajeev Gowda, son of Wharton Business School professor and former Karnataka speaker M.V. Venkatappa, to step into the political fray, especially after the recent five-day Karnataka darshan undertaken by AICC general secretary Rahul Gandhi. But with the exception of



a few young leaders like the state Youth Congress President Krishna Byregowda and his predecessor Dinesh Gundu Rao, not too many young leaders have been given tickets.

BJP, on the other hand, is hoping to make gains by pandering to the two dominant communities, especially the Lingayats who form nearly 15 per cent of Karnataka's population, are the largest vote bloc in the state and are traditional supporters of the party. Yeddyurappa himself is a Lingayat who has been going around with a clutch of promises including free power and low-cost bank loans for farmers. The party has not made any big moves to court minorities and its Bangalore (North) MP and former Bangalore police commissioner H.T. Sangliana has castigated the party publicly. "I was their minority face, having defeated two powerful leaders

DIVIDED HOUSE : Krishna (2nd from right) with other Congress leaders

from the Congress and JD(s) in the last Lok Sabha polls but today I am not being consulted even out of courtesy," says the Mizoram-born IPS officer, on whose life story three Kannada films have been made.

With just a month to go for the big fight and a new "popularly" elected government set to be appointed, a feeling of ennui has set in almost in all the main parties. Starting as a straight fight between BJP and the Congress party, the spotlight has fallen again on regional satraps like Deve Gowda and S. Bangarappa.

With migration to BJP set to continue, the Congress party is exploring the option of mending fences with former party leader Bangarappa, now the state unit chief of the Samajwadi Party (SP). The 74-year-old Bangarappa is a noted leader of the backward Idiga community from Shimoga. After he moved to BJP

from the Congress in 2004, he engineered victories in seven out of eight assembly seats in Shimoga district besides a win for himself, all on BJP tickets. With SP President Mulayam Singh Yadav showing his affinity to the Congress—he allowed his partymen to vote for a Congress-backed independent Rajya Sabha candidate recently in Madhya Pradesh—the Congress in Karnataka is definitely looking for all available crutches to make it to victory. ■

LAST HURRAH: For Gowda (left), there may not be another chance

